Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Marianne Moore's "Rosemary" and Thomas More's "Rosmarine"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

alliteration,
allusion,
myth,
mythopoeia,
personification,
reification,
rhyme,
theme, and
tone.

The young writer in comparing More's prose to Moore's poem should recognize that rosemary has been treated as a traditional symbol of remembrance by at least two writers, which should suggest something in the way of a cultural universality. That Marianne Moore directly quotes Thomas More ("hath a dumb language") might be seen as important in and of itself, but the connection should not be overemphasized or serve as the focus of the contestant's response.

The natural beauty of More's rosmarine and its attraction to the bees in his garden—the dumb language—is fleshed out in the Roman mythological figures of Venus and Cupid, then tied into the Christian story of the nativity and ultimate sacrifice, and is then remembered in the unmentioned pungency of the pagan [kind of] Christmas tree.

Colors, both implicitly presented (More's green and black) and enumerated (Moore's green, silver, white, and blue) might be the foundation of a comparison that contrasts More's remembrance-herb, which is focused on the physical, perhaps mortal, world (the garden, the bees, death, and burial) with Moore's "herb of memory," which is focused on the promise(s) of the spiritual world (the god and goddess of beauty and love, respectively), of escape (Egypt), of salvation (Christ), and a symbol of commemoration ("a kind of Christmas tree")—encompassing love, beauty, and salvation.

The contestant might well recognize More's connecting the herb to funeral wakes and burial and Moore's connecting rosemary with a specific (implied) death and burial as an indication of the symbolic importance of the herb, even across time and in differing contexts.